Three Mistakes Families Make When Checking Whether Dad's Care Covers Everything

Three assumptions to set down, and what to do in place of each.

Families checking on a parent's care tend to make the same three assumptions. None of them comes from carelessness, and each has a simple replacement.

1 Assuming a service on the schedule is being delivered

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The schedule on the fridge says an aide comes Monday, Wednesday and Friday mornings. When a cousin asks how Dad is, you say he has help three days a week. The visits happen while everyone is at work, and nobody in the family has seen one.

WHY IT HAPPENS The paper is what you were handed, so it stands in for the week. But a plan describes what is meant to happen. For a Medicare-certified home health agency, Medicare says the plan of care lists what services are needed, who should give them, and when and how often. That is an arrangement, not a record of visits. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Beside each service, write “seen” where you or someone you can name watched it happen this week, and “scheduled” where you're going on the paper. Then pick one scheduled line and ask about it, or be at the house the next time that help is due.

2 Treating something unconfirmed as if it has already failed

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Dad mentions he didn't get his shower on Friday. By evening the family group text has decided the agency is unreliable, and nobody has asked Dad, the aide or the agency's office what happened.

WHY IT HAPPENS When you're worried, an unanswered question feels like proof. But “we don't know” and “it didn't happen” are different lines on the page, and they lead to different phone calls.

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write it as a question someone can answer: what was expected, which day, and who would know. Then ask. The National Institute on Aging's advice is to mention your worry without sounding critical. Until there's an answer, the line stays under “not sure yet.” [2]

3 Missing the gaps one worn-out relative is quietly filling

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE “Dad's fine, everything's handled.” It is handled, because your sister stops by after work to make his supper, looks in on the mornings the aide isn't due, and does his laundry on Saturdays. None of that is written anywhere.

WHY IT HAPPENS Help that nobody asked for and nobody wrote down is easy to look past. It is also the usual kind: about 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers, and the National Institute on Aging notes that a primary caregiver may be hesitant to ask for help or a break. [3] [4]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask her to walk you through her week, day by day, and write it beside the plan. Note which of her tasks are also on the schedule as someone else's job. Then ask how she's holding up, and write down what she says. What you find is something to bring to the next care conversation. It isn't a sign that Dad is unsafe or that she has done anything wrong.

The habit that replaces all three

Beside every line, write how you know: “seen,” “told by,” or “not sure yet,” with a name and a date.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether Dad's care is working or whether anyone has fallen short. It names three assumptions the Family Care Roadmap sees often at this step, and a habit to use in place of each.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three assumptions to set down. The care interview puts something sturdier in their place: it goes through Dad's daily life one area at a time, asks who covers each part and how you know, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The description of a plan of care is Medicare's, written about Medicare-certified home health agencies. The figure for unpaid care is the Administration for Community Living's own, from its page on who provides care. The advice about raising a worry and the remark about primary caregivers come from the National Institute on Aging. The three mistakes themselves come from the Family Care Roadmap.

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Medicare & Home Health Care (CMS Product No. 10969)
2. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
3. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
4. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.